Learn French for Beginners

L'Hôtel des Fantômes Gentils

A story in 20 episodes · A1–B1

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The Hotel of Gentle Ghosts

A 20-episode cosy comedy: Lucie inherits a crumbling Alpine hotel and three polite, bored ghosts help her open it. Lucie, 29, has never lived anywhere for more than a year. Then her great-aunt Hortense leaves her an old twelve-room hotel above the Chamonix valley, closed for thirty-one years. Lucie plans to stay one night and sell. But three polite, very bored ghosts live there: Anselme, the innkeeper of the 1680s, Eulalie, a naturalist of 1786, and Marcel, the concierge of 1924. They can't lift a saucepan, but they know every secret of the house. With the village, they get it ready to open before Christmas. Each episode ends with a ghost's advice from their own century.

How to read

Each line gives the speaker and the French, then the English in italics. The respellings (English-style pronunciation, not IPA) are only in the word list at the end of each episode; ‿ marks a liaison there (*vous avez* = voo‿zah-vay). The questions for every episode and the answer key are at the end. The word in brackets after the English, such as *(teasing)*, says how the line is said.

Spelling	Sounds like
zh	the "s" in *measure* (French **j** / soft **g**)
uh	the "a" in *about*
ew	French **u**: say "ee" with your lips rounded like "oo"
N (capital)	nasal vowel: hum the vowel through your nose, don't say the "n"
ahN	nasal *an* / *en* (as in *France*)
ohN	nasal *on* (as in *bon*)
aN	nasal *in* / *ain* / *ien* (as in *vin*)
uhN	nasal *un* (as in *un*)
r	French throaty "r", made at the back of the throat
‿	liaison: the silent final consonant is pronounced at the start of the next word (*vous‿avez* = voo zah-vay)

The people

Lucie, hotel heiress (episodes 1, 2, 4, 5, 6, 10, 12, 14, 15, 17, 20)
Marcel, ghost concierge (episodes 1, 5, 8, 13, 14, 18, 20)
Anselme, ghost innkeeper (episodes 2, 7, 12, 19)
Bastien, carpenter (episodes 3, 6, 10, 15)
Eulalie, ghost naturalist (episodes 3, 8, 9, 11, 16, 18)
Gérard, estate agent (episode 4)
Josette, village grocer (episodes 7, 13)
Olivier, caller from Lyon (episode 9)
Nathan, mountain guide (episode 11)
Denis, fire safety inspector (episode 16)
Raymond, lost walker (episode 17)
Hélène, first guest (episode 19)

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Act 1 · Bienvenue ! (Welcome!)

Level A1

Episode 1 · L'héritière (The heiress)

On a windy, rainy Monday evening in September, Lucie opens the big oak door of the old hotel she has inherited above Chamonix, with one orange suitcase. The dark hall is full of dust sheets. The brass bell on the desk rings by itself, and Marcel, a tall concierge in a burgundy tailcoat with a soft lilac glow, appears behind it. When she says her name, he looks at her for a long moment, then leads her up the stairs with one brass key.

Lucie Bonjour ? Il y a quelqu'un ?
Hello? Is anyone there? (worried)

Marcel Bonsoir, madame. Bienvenue. Vous avez une réservation ?
Good evening, madam. Welcome. Do you have a booking? (proud)

Lucie Une réservation ? Mais c'est mon hôtel !
A booking? But it's my hotel! (surprised)

Marcel Votre hôtel ? Et madame Hortense ?
Your hotel? And Madame Hortense? (curious)

Lucie Ma tante Hortense n'est plus là. Je suis Lucie.
My aunt Hortense isn't here any more. I'm Lucie. (sad)

Marcel Je suis désolé, madame. Moi, c'est Marcel. Le concierge.
I'm so sorry, madam. I'm Marcel. The concierge. (moved)

Lucie Marcel… vous êtes transparent !
Marcel… you're see-through! (surprised)

Marcel Oui, madame. Je suis un fantôme. Un fantôme poli.
Yes, madam. I'm a ghost. A polite ghost. (amused)

Lucie Un fantôme, un toit cassé, pas de chauffage… C'est impossible !
A ghost, a broken roof, no heating… It's impossible! (annoyed)

Marcel Impossible ? Je ne connais pas ce mot, madame.
Impossible? I don't know that word, madam. (teasing)

Lucie Bon. Je reste une nuit. Une seule.
Fine. I'll stay one night. Just one. (hopeful)

Marcel Votre chambre est prête, madame. Depuis trente et un ans.
Your room is ready, madam. It has been for thirty-one years. (amused)

Words from this episode

- **Bonsoir** *(bohN-swahr)* — Good evening
- **Vous avez une réservation** *(voo‿zah-vay ewn ray-zair-vah-syohN)* — Do you have a booking (avoir: vous avez)
- **mon hôtel** *(mohN‿noh-tel)* — my hotel (mon, with a liaison before a vowel)
- **Ma tante** *(mah tahNt)* — My aunt (ma + feminine noun)
- **Je suis désolé** *(zhuh swee day-zoh-lay)* — I'm sorry (a man speaking; a woman says désolée)
- **vous êtes transparent** *(voo‿zet trahNs-pah-rahN)* — you're see-through (être: vous êtes)
- **Je suis un fantôme** *(zhuh swee uhN fahN-tohm)* — I'm a ghost (un + masculine noun)
- **Je ne connais pas ce mot** *(zhuh nuh koh-neh pah suh moh)* — I don't know that word (connaître)
- **Je reste une nuit** *(zhuh rest ewn nwee)* — I'm staying one night (rester)
- **trente et un ans** *(trahN-tay uhN‿nahN)* — thirty-one years (no liaison after et)

Notice: mon, ma, votre

Lucie says Mais c'est mon hôtel ! and Ma tante Hortense n'est plus là. Marcel answers Votre hôtel ? and Votre chambre est prête. Mon goes with a masculine noun and ma with a feminine one; votre means 'your' when you say vous, for both.

See the table: Grammar tables, Possessive adjectives: my, your, his...

Sagesse du jour

« Le vent se lève, il faut tenter de vivre. » *(luh vahN suh lev, eel foh tahN-tay duh vee-vruh)*

Literally: The wind is rising, one must try to live.

Meaning: When things get hard or start to change, don't give up: try, and live fully.

Episode 2 · La soupe (The soup)

On Tuesday morning at half past seven, Lucie eats biscuits from a packet at the long table in the cold stone kitchen. Anselme, a round innkeeper ghost in a leather apron with a warm amber glow, rises from the dead fireplace, outraged. Later Lucie chops a cabbage and carrots while Anselme points with his ghostly wooden ladle, and soon a pot steams over a real fire.

Anselme Morbleu ! Des biscuits, dans ma cuisine ?
Good heavens! Biscuits, in my kitchen? (annoyed)

Lucie Encore un fantôme ! Vous êtes qui ?
Another ghost! Who are you? (surprised)

Anselme Anselme, aubergiste. Ici, c'est mon auberge depuis seize cent quatre-vingts.
Anselme, innkeeper. This has been my inn since 1680. (proud)

Lucie Votre auberge ? Pardon, monsieur, c'est mon hôtel.
Your inn? Sorry, sir, it's my hotel. (teasing)

Anselme Madame, vous mangez quoi, le soir ? De la soupe ?
Madam, what do you eat in the evening? Soup? (curious)

Lucie Pas de soupe. Des biscuits. Je ne sais pas cuisiner.
No soup. Biscuits. I can't cook. (sad)

Lucie Vous faites la soupe, vous ?
Do you make soup, then? (curious)

Anselme Je ne peux pas. Mes mains ne tiennent rien.
I can't. My hands can't hold anything. (sad)

Anselme Mais je sais. Vous coupez, je dirige. D'accord ?
But I know how. You chop, I give the orders. All right? (hopeful)

Lucie D'accord, chef ! Du chou, des carottes, de l'eau…
OK, chef! Cabbage, carrots, water… (amused)

Lucie Mmm… C'est bon ! J'ai faim, maintenant.
Mmm… It's good! Now I'm hungry. (relieved)

Anselme Une maison commence dans la cuisine.
A home begins in the kitchen. (proud)

Words from this episode

- **Des biscuits** *(day bees-kwee)* — Biscuits, some biscuits (des: plural partitive)
- **vous mangez quoi** *(voo mahN-zhay kwah)* — what do you eat (manger)
- **De la soupe** *(duh lah soop)* — Some soup (de la + feminine noun)
- **Pas de soupe** *(pah duh soop)* — No soup (de after a negative)
- **Je ne sais pas cuisiner** *(zhuh nuh seh pah kwee-zee-nay)* — I can't cook (savoir + infinitive: know how to)
- **Vous faites la soupe** *(voo fet lah soop)* — You make the soup (faire: vous faites)
- **Je ne peux pas** *(zhuh nuh puh pah)* — I can't (pouvoir)
- **Mes mains ne tiennent rien** *(may maN nuh tyen ryaN)* — My hands can't hold anything (tenir: ils tiennent)
- **D'accord** *(dah-kor)* — OK, all right
- **J'ai faim** *(zhay faN)* — I'm hungry (literally: I have hunger)

Notice: du, de la, de l', des

Anselme asks De la soupe ? and Lucie lists Du chou, des carottes, de l'eau. French says du, de la, de l' or des for 'some' food. After a negative, they all become de: Pas de soupe.

See the table: Grammar tables, Partitive articles: some.

Sagesse du jour

« Il faut manger pour vivre et non pas vivre pour manger. » *(eel foh mahN-zhay poor vee-vruh ay nohN pah vee-vruh poor mahN-zhay)*

Literally: You must eat to live and not live to eat.

Meaning: Eat properly to stay well, but don't make food your whole life.

English equivalent: Eat to live, don't live to eat.

Episode 3 · Le télescope (The telescope)

At sunset on Thursday, Bastien, the village carpenter, pushes up the trapdoor of the turret to check the roof, while Lucie is at the notary's in Chamonix. At the round window, Eulalie, a lady ghost in pale-blue silk with an ice-blue glow, looks through a brass telescope at Mont Blanc and forgets to vanish. Bastien glances at her hovering feet and smiles. Later he bends to the eyepiece while she points at the pink summit.

Bastien Bonjour ? Oh ! Pardon, madame. Je suis Bastien, le menuisier.
Hello? Oh! Sorry, madam. I'm Bastien, the carpenter. (surprised)

Eulalie Chut ! Regardez. Quelle merveille ! Le mont Blanc est rose.
Shh! Look. What a marvel! Mont Blanc is pink. (curious)

Bastien Belle robe ! Vous faites un film ?
Nice dress! Are you making a film? (teasing)

Eulalie Je suis Eulalie. J'habite ici depuis mille sept cent quatre-vingt-six.
I'm Eulalie. I've lived here since 1786. (proud)

Bastien Bravo ! Vous êtes une actrice formidable.
Bravo! You're a wonderful actress. (amused)

Bastien Trois trous dans le toit. Là, là et là.
Three holes in the roof. There, there and there. (neutral)

Bastien Oh ! Je ne regarde jamais la montagne. Je travaille.
Oh! I never look at the mountain. I'm always working. (surprised)

Eulalie Cachée, je suis tranquille. Mais je m'ennuie.
Hidden, I'm safe and quiet. But I'm bored. (sad)

Eulalie Vous revenez demain ?
Are you coming back tomorrow? (hopeful)

Bastien Demain, avec des tuiles.
Tomorrow, with some tiles. (neutral)

Bastien À demain, madame l'actrice !
See you tomorrow, Madam Actress! (teasing)

Eulalie Une actrice… Il est gentil, ce monsieur.
An actress… He's sweet, that man. (amused)

Words from this episode

- **Pardon** *(par-dohN)* — Sorry, excuse me
- **Regardez** *(ruh-gar-day)* — Look (regarder: an order with vous)
- **J'habite ici** *(zhah-beet ee-see)* — I live here (habiter)
- **Trois trous** *(trwah troo)* — Three holes
- **dans le toit** *(dahN luh twah)* — in the roof (dans: in)
- **Je ne regarde jamais la montagne** *(zhuh nuh ruh-gard zhah-meh lah mohN-tahny)* — I never look at the mountain (ne… jamais)
- **Je travaille** *(zhuh trah-vahy)* — I work, I'm working (travailler)
- **Vous revenez demain** *(voo ruh-vuh-nay duh-maN)* — You're coming back tomorrow (revenir)
- **À demain** *(ah duh-maN)* — See you tomorrow

Notice: dans, sur, devant, ici, là

Bastien finds Trois trous dans le toit and points: Là, là et là. Eulalie says J'habite ici. Small words of place go before the noun: dans (in), sur (on), devant (in front of), derrière (behind); ici and là stand alone.

See the table: Grammar tables, Prepositions of place.

Sagesse du jour

« Pour vivre heureux, vivons cachés. » *(poor vee-vruh uh-ruh, vee-vohN kah-shay)*

Literally: To live happy, let's live hidden.

Meaning: A quiet life out of sight keeps you safe and content.

Episode 4 · L'agent immobilier (The estate agent)

On Saturday morning, Lucie shows Gérard, an estate agent from Chamonix with a laser measure and a tablet, round the dusty building; she means to sell. The three ghosts stay hidden but help quietly: a green shutter swings open on Mont Blanc, a fire lights itself in the salon and the piano plays three notes. Gérard blames draughts, and Lucie sees three faint, sad faces behind the long curtain.

Lucie Bonjour, monsieur. Voilà l'hôtel. Entrez !
Good morning. Here's the hotel. Come in! (hopeful)

Gérard Le toit est vieux. Les fenêtres sont vieilles.
The roof is old. The windows are old. (neutral)

Lucie Mais la vue est belle, non ?
But the view is lovely, isn't it? (hopeful)

Gérard Il y a des courants d'air, ici.
There are draughts in here. (US: drafts) (annoyed)

Gérard Mon prix : cent mille euros. Vous vendez vite ?
My price: a hundred thousand euros. Are you selling fast? (neutral)

Lucie Je change de ville tous les ans.
I move to a new city every year. (worried)

Lucie Je ne suis chez moi nulle part.
I'm not at home anywhere. (sad)

Gérard Le piano joue tout seul ?
The piano is playing by itself? (surprised)

Lucie Non. Je ne vends pas. Pas aujourd'hui.
No. I'm not selling. Not today. (proud)

Gérard Vous êtes sûre ? C'est une vieille maison.
Are you sure? It's an old house. (curious)

Lucie Une vieille maison… et une belle maison.
An old house… and a beautiful house. (proud)

Words from this episode

- **Bonjour** *(bohN-zhoor)* — Hello, good morning
- **Le toit est vieux** *(luh twah eh vyuh)* — The roof is old (vieux: masculine)
- **Les fenêtres sont vieilles** *(lay fuh-neh-truh sohN vyey)* — The windows are old (vieilles: feminine plural)
- **la vue est belle** *(lah vew eh bel)* — the view is beautiful (beau → belle)
- **cent mille euros** *(sahN mee-luh-roh)* — a hundred thousand euros
- **Vous vendez vite** *(voo vahN-day veet)* — You sell quickly (vendre)
- **Je change de ville** *(zhuh shahNzh duh veel)* — I move to another city (changer de: change one thing for another)
- **Je ne suis chez moi nulle part** *(zhuh nuh swee shay mwah newl par)* — I'm not at home anywhere (ne… nulle part)
- **Le piano joue tout seul** *(luh pyah-noh zhoo too suhl)* — The piano plays by itself (jouer)

Notice: vieux, vieille, belle

Gérard says Le toit est vieux and Les fenêtres sont vieilles; Lucie answers Une vieille maison… et une belle maison. Some adjectives change a lot in the feminine: vieux becomes vieille, and beau becomes belle.

See the table: Grammar tables, Common irregular adjectives.

Sagesse du jour

« Pierre qui roule n'amasse pas mousse. » *(pyair kee rool nah-mahs pah moos)*

Literally: A stone that rolls gathers no moss.

Meaning: If you never stay anywhere, you never build roots, friends or a home.

English equivalent: A rolling stone gathers no moss.

Episode 5 · Le pacte (The pact)

On Sunday evening in the salon, Lucie sits in an armchair with a blanket and a mug. The three ghosts line up in front of the fire like a delegation, Anselme glowing amber, Eulalie ice-blue and Marcel lilac, and Marcel steps forward; he glances at the green card table, then at Lucie, and smiles. During the rules Anselme walks in through the wall, and at the end four hands stack up like musketeers: Lucie's real hand under three glowing ones.

Marcel Madame, nous avons une proposition. Nous trois.
Madam, we have a proposal. The three of us. (proud)

Lucie Une proposition ? Quelle proposition ?
A proposal? What proposal? (curious)

Marcel Vous ouvrez l'hôtel. Et nous, nous aidons.
You open the hotel. And we help. (hopeful)

Lucie Vous aidez ? Mais vous ne portez rien !
You help? But you can't carry anything! (surprised)

Marcel Nous connaissons tout. Les clés, les recettes, les secrets.
We know everything. The keys, the recipes, the secrets. (teasing)

Lucie Et vous, qu'est-ce que vous voulez ?
And you, what do you want? (curious)

Marcel Des clients. On s'ennuie depuis trente et un ans.
Guests. We've been bored for thirty-one years. (sad)

Lucie Trois fantômes et moi… Les trois mousquetaires !
Three ghosts and me… The Three Musketeers! (amused)

Marcel Épatant ! Règle numéro un : on ne fait jamais peur.
Splendid! Rule number one: we never frighten anyone. (neutral)

Marcel Règle numéro deux : un fantôme ne ment jamais.
Rule number two: a ghost never lies. (proud)

Lucie Et règle numéro trois : on prend les portes !
And rule number three: we use the doors! (teasing)

Lucie D'accord. On ouvre le dix-neuf décembre. Ensemble.
All right. We open on the nineteenth of December. Together. (moved)

Words from this episode

- **Vous ouvrez l'hôtel** *(voo‿zoo-vray loh-tel)* — You open the hotel (ouvrir: vous ouvrez)
- **nous aidons** *(noo‿zay-dohN)* — we help (aider)
- **vous ne portez rien** *(voo nuh por-tay ryaN)* — you can't carry anything (porter; ne… rien)
- **Nous connaissons tout** *(noo koh-neh-sohN too)* — We know everything (connaître: nous connaissons)
- **Et vous** *(ay voo)* — And you
- **qu'est-ce que vous voulez** *(kes-kuh voo voo-lay)* — what do you want (vouloir)
- **trente et un ans** *(trahN-tay uhN‿nahN)* — thirty-one years
- **règle numéro un** *(reh-gluh new-may-roh uhN)* — rule number one
- **on prend les portes** *(ohN prahN lay port)* — we use the doors (prendre: take)
- **D'accord** *(dah-kor)* — All right, OK

Notice: un, deux, trois… dix-neuf

Marcel gives règle numéro un and règle numéro deux, and Lucie adds règle numéro trois. A date uses a plain number too: le dix-neuf décembre. For 31, trente et un, see the numbers from 21 to 100.

See the table: Grammar tables, Numbers 0–20.

Sagesse du jour

« L'important dans la vie, ce n'est point le triomphe mais le combat. » *(laN-por-tahN dahN lah vee, suh neh pwaN luh tree-ohNf meh luh kohN-bah)*

Literally: The important thing in life is not at all the triumph but the fight.

Meaning: What counts is to take part and do your best, not only to win.

Act 2 · Les travaux (The works)

Level A2

Episode 6 · Le toit (The roof)

On Friday morning after a night storm, buckets and pans catch drips in the hall, and Lucie, in yellow rain boots, holds a mop. Twenty pots of yellow paint she bought yesterday stand by the stairs. Bastien arrives with a ladder, and Anselme watches silently from the doorway with folded arms. Later Bastien works on the slate roof while Lucie climbs three steps of the ladder, eyes shut, and hands him a tile.

Lucie Il a plu toute la nuit. L'eau est entrée dans ma chambre.
It rained all night. The water came into my room. (worried)

Bastien On se dit tu ? À la montagne, tout le monde dit tu.
Shall we say tu? In the mountains, everybody says tu. (teasing)

Lucie D'accord. Alors… tu peux m'aider ?
OK. So… can you help me? (hopeful)

Bastien Tu as acheté de la peinture ? Et le toit ?
You bought paint? What about the roof? (surprised)

Lucie J'ai voulu aller trop vite.
I wanted to go too fast. (annoyed)

Lucie Moi, sur le toit ? Je ne suis jamais montée sur une échelle !
Me, on the roof? I've never been up a ladder! (worried)

Bastien D'abord le toit, après la peinture. On va commencer aujourd'hui.
First the roof, then the paint. We're going to start today. (neutral)

Bastien Et ton concierge en rouge ? Il est parti ?
And your concierge in red? Has he gone? (curious)

Lucie Euh… il est parti en vacances.
Er… he's gone on holiday. (US: on vacation) (amused)

Lucie Je suis montée ! Trois marches !
I climbed up! Three steps! (proud)

Bastien Il fait un temps de chien, mais demain, il va faire beau.
The weather's awful, but tomorrow it's going to be fine. (hopeful)

Words from this episode

- **Il a plu** *(eel ah plew)* — It rained (pleuvoir, with avoir)
- **L'eau est entrée** *(loh eh ahN-tray)* — The water came in (entrer, with être: -e for l'eau)
- **On se dit tu** *(ohN suh dee tew)* — Let's say tu to each other (informal you)
- **D'accord** *(dah-kor)* — OK, all right
- **Tu as acheté** *(tew ah ahsh-tay)* — You bought (acheter, with avoir)
- **Je ne suis jamais montée** *(zhuh nuh swee zhah-meh mohN-tay)* — I've never climbed (monter, with être)
- **On va commencer** *(ohN vah koh-mahN-say)* — We're going to start (commencer)
- **Il est parti** *(eel eh par-tee)* — He has gone, he left (partir, with être)
- **Je suis montée** *(zhuh swee mohN-tay)* — I climbed up (monter, with être: -e for a woman)
- **Il fait un temps de chien** *(eel feh uhN tahN duh shyaN)* — The weather's awful (literally: a dog's weather)

Notice: Je suis montée, j'ai voulu

Lucie says L'eau est entrée and Je suis montée !, and Bastien asks Il est parti ?: verbs of movement take être, and the participle agrees (montée for Lucie). Most verbs take avoir: Il a plu, Tu as acheté, J'ai voulu. Bastien also proposes On se dit tu ?, and from now on he and Lucie say tu.

See the table: Grammar tables, Verbs that take être in the passé composé.

Sagesse du jour

« Il ne faut pas mettre la charrue avant les bœufs. » *(eel nuh foh pah meh-truh lah shah-rew ah-vahN lay buh)*

Literally: You mustn't put the plough before the oxen.

Meaning: Do things in the right order: the most important step comes first.

English equivalent: Don't put the cart before the horse.

Episode 7 · La tartiflette (The tartiflette)

On Thursday afternoon, Josette, the small village grocer, pulls her wicker basket on wheels into the kitchen: potatoes, onions, lardons and a whole reblochon. She has come to teach Lucie the tartiflette, but Lucie is at the hardware shop with Bastien, so she finds Anselme instead, his amber glow flaring as he knows her. Anselme bends to sniff the dish with his eyes closed, and later Josette takes a golden, bubbling tartiflette out of the oven while he applauds.

Josette Bonjour, Anselme ! Vous ne m'avez pas oubliée ?
Hello, Anselme! You haven't forgotten me? (amused)

Anselme Josette ! La petite Josette ! Vous avez grandi !
Josette! Little Josette! You've grown! (surprised)

Josette J'ai soixante-seize ans, Anselme.
I'm seventy-six, Anselme. (teasing)

Josette En mille neuf cent cinquante-huit, je vous ai vu. J'ai eu peur !
In 1958, I saw you. I got such a fright! (amused)

Anselme Peur ? De moi ? Oh, ça sent bon ! Qu'est-ce que c'est ?
A fright? From me? Oh, that smells good! What is it? (curious)

Josette Une tartiflette. Le plat traditionnel de la Savoie.
A tartiflette. The traditional dish of Savoy. (proud)

Anselme Traditionnel ? Je n'ai jamais mangé ça. Et je suis savoyard !
Traditional? I've never eaten that. And I'm from Savoy! (surprised)

Josette On a inventé la tartiflette dans les années quatre-vingt. Pour le reblochon !
They invented tartiflette in the eighties. To sell reblochon cheese! (amused)

Anselme Du fromage, des oignons… Moi aussi, j'ai fait ça !
Cheese, onions… I made that too! (proud)

Josette Hortense m'a demandé une chose : aider la petite.
Hortense asked me one thing: to help the girl. (moved)

Josette Toutes les traditions ont été nouvelles, un jour.
Every tradition was new once. (hopeful)

Anselme Ce soir, on va commencer une tradition !
Tonight, we're going to start a tradition! (hopeful)

Words from this episode

- **Bonjour** *(bohN-zhoor)* — Hello
- **Vous ne m'avez pas oubliée** *(voo nuh mah-vay pah oo-blee-yay)* — You haven't forgotten me (oublier; -e because me is a woman)
- **soixante-seize ans** *(swah-sahNt-seh-zahN)* — seventy-six years old
- **En mille neuf cent cinquante-huit** *(ahN meel nuhf sahN saN-kahNt-weet)* — In 1958 (en + a year)
- **ça sent bon** *(sah sahN bohN)* — that smells good (sentir)
- **Je n'ai jamais mangé ça** *(zhuh nay zhah-meh mahN-zhay sah)* — I've never eaten that (manger)
- **dans les années quatre-vingt** *(dahN lay‿zah-nay kah-truh-vaN)* — in the eighties (dans les années + a decade)
- **Du fromage, des oignons** *(dew froh-mahzh, day‿zoh-nyohN)* — Cheese, onions (some: du, des)
- **Moi aussi** *(mwah oh-see)* — Me too
- **on va commencer** *(ohN vah koh-mahN-say)* — we're going to start (commencer)

Notice: en 1958, dans les années quatre-vingt, ce soir

Josette says En mille neuf cent cinquante-huit, je vous ai vu and On a inventé la tartiflette dans les années quatre-vingt. Use en + a year and dans les années + a decade; ce soir and un jour need no little word in front.

See the table: Grammar tables, Common time expressions.

Sagesse du jour

« Rien de nouveau sous le soleil. » *(ryaN duh noo-voh soo luh soh-lehy)*

Literally: Nothing new under the sun.

Meaning: What looks new has usually been done before, in another form.

English equivalent: There's nothing new under the sun.

Episode 8 · Les noms des chambres (The room names)

At three in the morning, in the moonlit second-floor corridor, Eulalie and Marcel meet nose to nose while Lucie sleeps in room seven. Eulalie has put a dried alpine sprig from her old herbarium in each room; Marcel has polished the twelve keys with a small cloth. They swap jobs: Eulalie rubs a key dull and streaky and drops it under the radiator, and Marcel knocks over a tin cup of sprigs, scattering petals on the runner. At dawn, both are laughing.

Eulalie Vous avez vu ? J'ai trouvé douze noms. Douze fleurs !
Have you seen? I've found twelve names. Twelve flowers! (proud)

Marcel Des fleurs ? Un hôtel a des numéros, madame.
Flowers? A hotel has numbers, madam. (teasing)

Eulalie Les numéros, c'est triste. Rhododendron… quelle merveille !
Numbers are sad. Rhododendron… what a marvel! (teasing)

Marcel Rhodo… quoi ? N'importe quoi ! Les clients ne vont jamais dire ça !
Rhodo-what? Nonsense! The guests are never going to say that! (amused)

Eulalie Et vous, vous n'avez rien fait de la nuit !
And you, you haven't done a thing all night! (annoyed)

Marcel Rien ? J'ai fait briller les douze clés. Deux fois !
Nothing? I polished all twelve keys. Twice! (proud)

Eulalie Oh… en fait, c'est difficile, votre travail.
Oh… actually, your job is hard. (surprised)

Marcel Le vôtre aussi, madame.
So is yours, madam. (relieved)

Eulalie Chambre un, Edelweiss. Chambre deux, Gentiane. Et le numéro reste.
Room one, Edelweiss. Room two, Gentian. And the number stays. (hopeful)

Marcel La chambre sept, c'est Myosotis. Pour madame Lucie.
Room seven is Forget-me-not. For Madame Lucie. (moved)

Marcel Tous les jours, je vais de mieux en mieux.
Every day, I'm getting better and better. (proud)

Eulalie Vous dites ça depuis cent ans, monsieur Marcel.
You've been saying that for a hundred years, Monsieur Marcel. (amused)

Words from this episode

- **J'ai trouvé douze noms** *(zhay troo-vay dooz nohN)* — I've found twelve names (trouver)
- **Douze fleurs** *(dooz fluhr)* — Twelve flowers
- **N'importe quoi** *(naN-port kwah)* — Nonsense!
- **Les clients ne vont jamais dire ça** *(lay klee-yahN nuh vohN zhah-meh deer sah)* — The guests are never going to say that (ne… jamais around aller)
- **vous n'avez rien fait** *(voo nah-vay ryaN feh)* — you haven't done anything (ne… rien around avoir)
- **J'ai fait briller les douze clés** *(zhay feh bree-yay lay dooz klay)* — I polished the twelve keys (literally: I made them shine)
- **en fait** *(ahN fet)* — actually, in fact
- **La chambre sept** *(lah shahN-bruh set)* — Room seven
- **je vais de mieux en mieux** *(zhuh veh duh myuh‿zahN myuh)* — I'm getting better and better (aller: je vais)
- **Vous dites ça** *(voo deet sah)* — You say that (dire: vous dites)

Notice: ne… rien, ne… jamais

Eulalie says Vous n'avez rien fait de la nuit !: in the passé composé, ne… rien goes around the auxiliary avoir. With aller + infinitive, it goes around aller: Les clients ne vont jamais dire ça !

See the table: Grammar tables, Where the negative goes.

Sagesse du jour

« La critique est aisée, et l'art est difficile. » *(lah kree-teek eh eh-zay, ay lar eh dee-fee-seel)*

Literally: Criticism is easy, and art is difficult.

Meaning: It's easy to find fault in other people's work; doing it yourself is hard.

Episode 9 · La première réservation (The first booking)

On Wednesday afternoon, the black rotary telephone at reception rings for the first time in thirty-one years, while Lucie is at the bank. Eulalie, who has never seen a telephone, holds the receiver at arm's length, astonished. Behind her, Marcel silently mimes 'put it to your ear' and mouths the price. At the end Eulalie writes the booking in the big leather register with a floating pencil, Marcel peering over her shoulder.

Eulalie Allô ? Oh ! Il y a une voix dans la boîte !
Hello? Oh! There's a voice in the box! (surprised)

Olivier Bonjour, madame. Ici Olivier Garnier. C'est bien l'hôtel du Belvédère ?
Hello, madam. This is Olivier Garnier. Is that the Hôtel du Belvédère? (neutral)

Eulalie Oui, monsieur. Quelle merveille ! Vous êtes où ? Dans la boîte ?
Yes, sir. What a marvel! Where are you? In the box? (curious)

Olivier Je suis à Lyon ! Je voudrais une chambre, le dix-neuf décembre.
I'm in Lyon! I'd like a room for the nineteenth of December. (amused)

Eulalie Plus lentement, s'il vous plaît.
More slowly, please. (worried)

Olivier Deux adultes et deux enfants : Margot, huit ans, et Sacha, cinq ans.
Two adults and two children: Margot, eight, and Sacha, five. (neutral)

Eulalie On va faire du chocolat chaud. Et les étoiles, au télescope !
We'll make hot chocolate. And the stars, through the telescope! (hopeful)

Olivier Un télescope ? C'est génial ! On va la prendre. C'est combien ?
A telescope? That's great! We'll take it. How much is it? (surprised)

Eulalie Cent vingt euros, monsieur.
A hundred and twenty euros, sir. (neutral)

Eulalie Monsieur Garnier, vous êtes notre premier client !
Monsieur Garnier, you're our first guest! (proud)

Olivier Merci, madame. Vous avez un accent… très ancien.
Thank you, madam. You have an accent… a very old one. (amused)

Words from this episode

- **Je voudrais une chambre** *(zhuh voo-dreh ewn shahN-bruh)* — I'd like a room
- **le dix-neuf décembre** *(luh deez-nuhf day-sahN-bruh)* — on the nineteenth of December (le + number + month)
- **Plus lentement, s'il vous plaît** *(plew lahNt-mahN, seel voo pleh)* — More slowly, please
- **huit ans** *(wee‿tahN)* — eight years old (t-liaison)
- **On va faire du chocolat chaud** *(ohN vah fair dew shoh-koh-lah shoh)* — We're going to make hot chocolate (faire)
- **C'est génial** *(seh zhay-nyahl)* — That's great!
- **On va la prendre** *(ohN vah lah prahN-druh)* — We'll take it (prendre; la = the room)
- **C'est combien** *(seh kohN-byaN)* — How much is it?
- **Cent vingt euros** *(sahN vaN‿tuh-roh)* — A hundred and twenty euros (t-liaison after vingt)

Notice: le dix-neuf décembre

Olivier wants a room le dix-neuf décembre. For a date, say le + the number + the month, and write the month without a capital letter. For the whole month, say en: en décembre.

See the table: Grammar tables, Months.

Sagesse du jour

« Le superflu, chose très nécessaire. » *(luh sew-pair-flew, shohz treh nay-seh-sair)*

Literally: The superfluous, a very necessary thing.

Meaning: The small extras that seem useless are what make life pleasant.

Episode 10 · Tout le village (The whole village)

On Saturday evening, Lucie sits on the wide staircase among plain envelopes, a pocket calculator face down beside her, her head in her hands. Bastien comes in with his toolbox and sits down next to her. The three ghosts watch faintly over the banister above; when Bastien names Marcel, Marcel bows low from the landing and his glow brightens, and Lucie laughs.

Lucie La banque a dit non. Il me manque vingt mille euros.
The bank said no. I'm twenty thousand euros short. (worried)

Lucie J'ai toujours tout fait seule. Je vais vendre.
I've always done everything on my own. I'm going to sell. (sad)

Bastien Tu as demandé de l'aide ? À quelqu'un ?
Have you asked for help? From anyone? (curious)

Lucie Demander de l'aide ? Je ne sais pas faire ça.
Ask for help? I don't know how to do that. (annoyed)

Lucie Je suis venue une fois, à huit ans. C'est tout.
I came here once, when I was eight. That's all. (neutral)

Bastien Ma grand-mère a appelé tout le village. Samedi, on vient tous.
My grandmother has phoned the whole village. On Saturday, we're all coming. (hopeful)

Lucie Tout le village ? Pour moi ?
The whole village? For me? (moved)

Lucie Bastien, je dois te dire… Les acteurs, ce sont des fantômes.
Bastien, I have to tell you… The actors are ghosts. (worried)

Bastien Je sais. J'ai vu Marcel en mille neuf cent quatre-vingt-seize.
I know. I saw Marcel in 1996. (amused)

Lucie Tu es au courant ? Depuis le début ?
You knew? Since the beginning? (surprised)

Bastien Ma grand-mère m'a tout raconté. Et ils sont gentils, non ?
My grandmother told me everything. And they're nice, aren't they? (teasing)

Lucie Samedi, on va réparer l'hôtel. Ensemble.
On Saturday, we're going to repair the hotel. Together. (hopeful)

Words from this episode

- **vingt mille euros** *(vaN mee-luh-roh)* — twenty thousand euros
- **Je vais vendre** *(zhuh veh vahN-druh)* — I'm going to sell (aller + infinitive)
- **Tu as demandé de l'aide** *(tew ah duh-mahN-day duh led)* — You asked for help (demander)
- **Je ne sais pas faire ça** *(zhuh nuh seh pah fair sah)* — I don't know how to do that (savoir + infinitive)
- **Je suis venue** *(zhuh swee vuh-new)* — I came (venir, with être: -e for a woman)
- **C'est tout** *(seh too)* — That's all
- **Ma grand-mère a appelé tout le village** *(mah grahN-mair ah ah-puh-lay too luh vee-lahzh)* — My grandmother has phoned the whole village (appeler)
- **m'a tout raconté** *(mah too rah-kohN-tay)* — told me everything (raconter)
- **on va réparer** *(ohN vah ray-pah-ray)* — we're going to repair (aller + infinitive)

Notice: je vais vendre, on va réparer

Lucie says Je vais vendre, then Samedi, on va réparer l'hôtel: aller in the present + an infinitive gives the near future. For a fixed plan, French often keeps the present: Samedi, on vient tous.

See the table: Grammar tables, Futur simple: endings and irregular stems.

Sagesse du jour

« Aide-toi, le ciel t'aidera. » *(ed-twah, luh syel teh-duh-rah)*

Literally: Help yourself, heaven will help you.

Meaning: Make the first move yourself, and help will come.

English equivalent: God helps those who help themselves.

Act 3 · Les souvenirs (Memories (A2+))

Level A2

Episode 11 · Le sommet (The summit)

On Monday afternoon, in low golden light, Nathan, a young mountain guide from Chamonix with an orange jacket and a red rope, comes up through the trapdoor of the turret; Lucie has sent him up for the view. Eulalie is at the brass telescope and tells him plainly what she is. Cowbells ring from the valley below. Later Nathan bends to the eyepiece while Eulalie points at the summit, her blue glow bright.

Nathan Bonjour ! On m'a dit : la plus belle vue de la vallée est ici.
Hello! I was told the best view in the valley is up here. (curious)

Eulalie C'est vrai. En mille sept cent quatre-vingt-six, je regardais le sommet d'ici.
It's true. In 1786, I used to watch the summit from here. (proud)

Nathan En mille sept cent quatre-vingt-six ? Vous êtes bien conservée, madame !
In 1786? You're well preserved, madam! (amused)

Eulalie Deux hommes montaient. Balmat et Paccard. Toute la vallée les regardait.
Two men were climbing. Balmat and Paccard. The whole valley was watching them. (moved)

Eulalie Le huit août, le soir, ils étaient en haut. J'ai pleuré de joie.
On the eighth of August, in the evening, they were at the top. I cried with joy. (moved)

Eulalie Moi aussi, je voulais monter. Mais une dame, à cette époque…
I wanted to climb too. But a lady, in those days… (sad)

Nathan La première femme est montée en mille huit cent huit. Marie Paradis.
The first woman went up in 1808. Marie Paradis. (neutral)

Eulalie Une femme ! Quelle merveille ! Qui était-elle ?
A woman! What a marvel! Who was she? (surprised)

Nathan Une femme de Chamonix. Aujourd'hui, de plus en plus de femmes sont guides.
A woman from Chamonix. Today, more and more women are guides. (proud)

Eulalie Et vous, vous connaissez les fleurs, là-haut ?
And you, do you know the flowers up there? (curious)

Nathan Pas du tout. Moi, je monte, c'est tout.
Not at all. Me, I just climb, that's all. (amused)

Nathan Vous devriez montrer la montagne aux clients. Avec ce télescope.
You should show the mountain to the guests. With this telescope. (hopeful)

Eulalie Vous montez, je regarde, et je raconte. Chacun son travail !
You climb, I watch, and I tell the story. Each to their own job! (hopeful)

Words from this episode

- **je regardais le sommet** *(zhuh ruh-gar-deh luh soh-meh)* — I used to watch the summit (imparfait)
- **Deux hommes montaient** *(duh‿zum mohN-teh)* — Two men were climbing (monter, imparfait)
- **Toute la vallée les regardait** *(toot lah vah-lay lay ruh-gar-deh)* — The whole valley was watching them (regarder)
- **J'ai pleuré de joie** *(zhay pluh-ray duh zhwah)* — I cried with joy (pleurer, passé composé)
- **je voulais monter** *(zhuh voo-leh mohN-tay)* — I wanted to climb (vouloir, imparfait)
- **La première femme** *(lah pruh-myair fam)* — The first woman
- **Pas du tout** *(pah dew too)* — Not at all
- **c'est tout** *(seh too)* — that's all
- **Vous devriez montrer** *(voo duh-vree-yay mohN-tray)* — You should show (devoir in the conditional + infinitive)
- **Chacun son travail** *(shah-kuhN sohN trah-vahy)* — Each to their own job

Notice: je regardais / j'ai pleuré

Eulalie remembers with the imparfait: je regardais le sommet, deux hommes montaient, toute la vallée les regardait, je voulais monter. That is the scene, the background and the wish. For one event she switches to the passé composé: J'ai pleuré de joie, and Nathan says La première femme est montée.

See the table: Grammar tables, Imparfait: how things were, what used to happen.

Sagesse du jour

« Chacun son métier, les vaches seront bien gardées. » *(shah-kuhN sohN may-tyay, lay vahsh suh-rohN byaN gar-day)*

Literally: Each to his trade, the cows will be well guarded.

Meaning: Let everyone do the job they know best, and all will go well.

English equivalent: Every man to his trade.

Episode 12 · L'auberge (The old inn)

Late on Thursday night in the kitchen, Lucie is still sanding a door at the long table, for the third night running. Anselme sits across from her, his amber glow lighting her like a fireside, and remembers the mules and muleteers in front of the old stone inn. After they say good night, Lucie dozes off over her folded arms before going up, and Anselme very carefully lays a light wool shawl over her shoulders.

Lucie Encore une porte, et après, je vais dormir. Promis.
One more door, and then I'll go to bed. Promise. (worried)

Anselme Vous dites ça depuis trois nuits, madame.
You've been saying that for three nights, madam. (teasing)

Lucie Anselme, comment c'était, ici, avant ? Votre auberge ?
Anselme, what was it like here before? Your inn? (curious)

Anselme Il y avait des mules, des marchands, du sel. Ils allaient en Italie.
There were mules, merchants, salt. They were going to Italy. (moved)

Anselme Les muletiers étaient malins. Ils ne fatiguaient jamais leurs mules.
The muleteers were clever. They never wore out their mules. (amused)

Lucie Et vous étiez français ?
And were you French? (curious)

Anselme Français ? Point du tout ! J'étais savoyard. La Savoie était un pays.
French? Not at all! I was Savoyard. Savoy was a country. (proud)

Anselme La Savoie est devenue française en mille huit cent soixante.
Savoy became French in 1860. (neutral)

Lucie Alors, vous êtes français depuis cent soixante-six ans !
So you've been French for a hundred and sixty-six years! (amused)

Anselme Je suis savoyard, l'hôtel est français, et je suis chez moi.
I'm Savoyard, the hotel is French, and I'm at home. (moved)

Anselme Vous devriez dormir, madame. Une mule fatiguée ne monte pas le col.
You should sleep, madam. A tired mule doesn't get up the pass. (hopeful)

Lucie Vous avez raison. Bonne nuit, Anselme.
You're right. Good night, Anselme. (relieved)

Anselme Bonne nuit. Demain, soupe aux choux. Comme en seize cent quatre-vingts.
Good night. Tomorrow, cabbage soup. Like in 1680. (proud)

Words from this episode

- **je vais dormir** *(zhuh veh dor-meer)* — I'm going to sleep (dormir)
- **comment c'était** *(koh-mahN seh-teh)* — what was it like (imparfait of c'est)
- **Ils allaient en Italie** *(eel‿zah-leh ahN‿nee-tah-lee)* — They were going to Italy (en + feminine country)
- **Point du tout** *(pwaN dew too)* — Not at all! (old-fashioned)
- **La Savoie est devenue française** *(lah sah-vwah eh duh-vuh-new frahN-sez)* — Savoy became French (devenir, with être)
- **cent soixante-six ans** *(sahN swah-sahNt-see‿zahN)* — a hundred and sixty-six years
- **je suis chez moi** *(zhuh swee shay mwah)* — I'm at home
- **Vous devriez dormir** *(voo duh-vree-yay dor-meer)* — You should sleep (devoir in the conditional + infinitive)
- **Vous avez raison** *(voo‿zah-vay reh-zohN)* — You're right (literally: you have reason)
- **Bonne nuit** *(bun nwee)* — Good night

Notice: Vous devriez dormir

Anselme gives advice with Vous devriez dormir, madame: devoir in the conditional + an infinitive means 'you should'. With tu, it is tu devrais; and il faut + infinitive (Il faut dormir) is a firmer 'you must'.

See the table: Grammar tables, Conditional: would, could, polite requests.

Sagesse du jour

« Qui veut voyager loin ménage sa monture. » *(kee vuh vwah-yah-zhay lwaN may-nahzh sah mohN-tewr)*

Literally: Who wants to travel far spares his mount.

Meaning: Look after your strength if you want to go a long way.

Episode 13 · Les Jeux d'hiver (The Winter Games)

On Wednesday afternoon in the hall, Josette holds out an old sepia photo she found in her attic: the hotel staff on the snowy front steps, January 1924. In the middle stands young Marcel; beside him, a smiling chambermaid in a white cap. Marcel leans in, his lilac glow trembling, and strikes his 1924 pose for comparison. Later, by the salon fire, he tells the story with his hands raised while Josette laughs in an armchair.

Josette Marcel, regardez cette photo. Elle était dans mon grenier.
Marcel, look at this photo. It was in my attic. (curious)

Marcel Le personnel, en janvier mille neuf cent vingt-quatre ! Et là, c'est moi.
The staff, in January 1924! And there, that's me. (moved)

Josette Et cette jeune femme, à côté de vous ?
And this young woman next to you? (curious)

Marcel Germaine, la femme de chambre. Elle chantait tout le temps.
Germaine, the chambermaid. She was always singing. (amused)

Josette Germaine, c'était ma grand-mère.
Germaine was my grandmother. (moved)

Marcel Votre grand-mère ! Vous avez son sourire, madame.
Your grandmother! You have her smile, madam. (surprised)

Josette Comment c'était, les Jeux ?
What were the Games like? (curious)

Marcel L'hôtel était plein. Il y avait des patineurs, des skieurs, des Américains…
The hotel was full. There were skaters, skiers, Americans… (proud)

Marcel C'étaient les premiers Jeux olympiques d'hiver. À Chamonix !
They were the first Winter Olympic Games. In Chamonix! (proud)

Marcel Il faisait moins vingt. Mais tout le monde riait quand même.
It was minus twenty. But everyone laughed all the same. (amused)

Marcel Après cet hiver, l'hôtel était calme. Je pensais toujours à ces jours-là.
After that winter, the hotel was quiet. I always thought about those days. (sad)

Josette Vous devriez raconter ces histoires aux clients. Le soir, au salon.
You should tell those stories to the guests. In the evening, in the lounge. (hopeful)

Marcel Des histoires au salon… C'est épatant ! Les skis changent, les gens non.
Stories in the lounge… Splendid! Skis change; people don't. (hopeful)

Words from this episode

- **regardez cette photo** *(ruh-gar-day set foh-toh)* — look at this photo (cette + feminine noun)
- **Elle était dans mon grenier** *(el ay-teh dahN mohN gruh-nyay)* — It was in my attic (être, imparfait)
- **en janvier** *(ahN zhahN-vyay)* — in January
- **Elle chantait tout le temps** *(el shahN-teh too luh tahN)* — She was always singing (chanter, imparfait)
- **tout le monde riait** *(too luh mohNd ree-yeh)* — everyone was laughing (rire, imparfait)
- **quand même** *(kahN mem)* — all the same, anyway
- **cet hiver** *(set ee-vair)* — that winter (cet before a vowel)
- **Vous devriez raconter ces histoires** *(voo duh-vree-yay rah-kohN-tay say‿zees-twahr)* — You should tell those stories (raconter)
- **C'est épatant** *(seh‿tay-pah-tahN)* — Splendid! (old-fashioned)
- **Les skis changent** *(lay skee shahNzh)* — Skis change (changer)

Notice: ce, cet, cette, ces

Josette says regardez cette photo and asks about cette jeune femme; Marcel remembers cet hiver and ces jours-là, and Josette wants ces histoires for the guests. Ce goes with a masculine noun, cet with a masculine noun starting with a vowel sound, cette with a feminine noun and ces with any plural.

See the table: Grammar tables, Demonstrative adjectives: this, that, these.

Sagesse du jour

« Tous les jours, à tous points de vue, je vais de mieux en mieux. » *(too lay zhoor, ah too pwaN duh vew, zhuh veh duh myuh‿zahN myuh)*

Literally: Every day, from every point of view, I am going better and better.

Meaning: Tell yourself each day that things are getting better: your best days can still be ahead.

English equivalent: Every day, in every way, I'm getting better and better.

Episode 14 · Tante Hortense (Aunt Hortense)

On Sunday afternoon in the salon, Lucie opens the drawer of the green card table and finds a worn deck of cards. Marcel stops polishing, his lilac glow trembling, a white glove on his heart. As he remembers, Lucie sees the summer of 2005 again: a little girl in a yellow raincoat playing cards with a glowing man in red while Hortense laughs in the doorway. At the end, Lucie and Marcel sit down at the card table, and Anselme and Eulalie peek in from the doorway.

Marcel Chic ! Vous avez trouvé les cartes de madame Hortense !
Splendid! You've found Madame Hortense's cards! (surprised)

Lucie Elle jouait aux cartes ? Avec qui ?
She played cards? Who with? (curious)

Marcel Avec moi. Chaque dimanche. Elle trichait toujours, et je perdais toujours.
With me. Every Sunday. She always cheated, and I always lost. (amused)

Lucie Ma tante trichait ? Racontez-moi, Marcel. Comment était-elle ?
My aunt cheated? Tell me, Marcel. What was she like? (teasing)

Marcel Elle était petite et forte. Elle riait tout le temps.
She was small and strong. She laughed all the time. (moved)

Marcel Elle a gardé l'hôtel seule pendant seize ans.
She kept the hotel going on her own for sixteen years. (neutral)

Lucie Pourquoi est-ce qu'elle a fermé l'hôtel ?
Why did she close the hotel? (sad)

Marcel Elle était fatiguée. Elle n'avait personne pour continuer.
She was tired. She had no one to carry on. (sad)

Marcel Mais un été, elle est venue avec une petite fille de huit ans.
But one summer, she came with a little girl of eight. (hopeful)

Lucie Moi ? En deux mille cinq ? Je me souviens ! Le monsieur en rouge !
Me? In 2005? I remember! The man in red! (surprised)

Marcel La petite n'avait pas peur. Elle a dit : « Bonjour, fantôme. On joue ? »
The little girl wasn't scared. She said: 'Hello, ghost. Shall we play?' (moved)

Marcel Madame Hortense disait : « Une maison, c'est une porte ouverte. »
Madame Hortense used to say: 'A home is an open door.' (proud)

Lucie Bon. Alors, j'ouvre la porte. Pour elle. Et maintenant… on joue ?
Right. Then I'll open the door. For her. And now… shall we play? (hopeful)

Words from this episode

- **Elle jouait aux cartes** *(el zhoo-eh oh kart)* — She used to play cards (jouer à, imparfait)
- **Elle trichait toujours** *(el tree-sheh too-zhoor)* — She always cheated (imparfait: a habit)
- **je perdais toujours** *(zhuh pair-deh too-zhoor)* — I always lost (perdre, imparfait)
- **Elle a gardé l'hôtel** *(el ah gar-day loh-tel)* — She kept the hotel going (garder)
- **seize ans** *(seh-zahN)* — sixteen years
- **elle a fermé l'hôtel** *(el ah fair-may loh-tel)* — she closed the hotel (fermer)
- **elle est venue** *(el eh vuh-new)* — she came (venir, with être)
- **Je me souviens** *(zhuh muh soo-vyaN)* — I remember (se souvenir)
- **Bon** *(bohN)* — Right, well
- **j'ouvre la porte** *(zhoo-vruh lah port)* — I open the door (ouvrir)

Notice: elle trichait / elle a fermé

Marcel describes Hortense's habits with the imparfait: elle jouait, elle trichait, elle riait, elle disait. For single events he uses the passé composé: elle a gardé l'hôtel, elle a fermé l'hôtel, elle est venue avec une petite fille.

See the table: Grammar tables, Imparfait: how things were, what used to happen.

Sagesse du jour

« Aujourd'hui plus qu'hier et bien moins que demain. » *(oh-zhoor-dwee plew kyair ay byaN mwaN kuh duh-maN)*

Literally: Today more than yesterday and much less than tomorrow.

Meaning: Love for the people you care about grows a little more every day.

Episode 15 · La véranda (The veranda)

On a frosty Saturday morning in the long glass veranda of 1908, Lucie holds a glossy brochure from a window company and Bastien holds an old wooden frame. Many of the forty small panes are cracked. Anselme sits in a wicker chair, silent, nodding like a judge. Bastien guides Lucie's hand as she puts in a new pane with a putty knife; the putty cracks twice, and on the third try sunlight shines through one perfect new pane.

Lucie Le monsieur des fenêtres a dit : tout en plastique, en une semaine.
The window man said: all in plastic, in one week. (neutral)

Bastien Du plastique ? Sur une véranda de mille neuf cent huit ?
Plastic? On a veranda from 1908? (annoyed)

Lucie Réparer, c'est trop long. Il y a quarante vitres !
Repairing takes too long. There are forty panes! (worried)

Bastien Quand j'étais petit, je regardais cette véranda. Elle brillait comme un bijou.
When I was little, I used to look at this veranda. It shone like a jewel. (moved)

Bastien Tu devrais la garder. On la répare, une vitre à la fois.
You should keep it. We'll repair it, one pane at a time. (hopeful)

Lucie Je l'ai ratée. Encore !
I've botched it. Again! (annoyed)

Bastien Tant pis. Recommence. Moi, j'ai raté ma première fenêtre dix fois.
Never mind. Start again. I botched my first window ten times. (amused)

Lucie Ça y est ! Elle est parfaite. Plus que trente-neuf.
Done it! It's perfect. Only thirty-nine to go. (proud)

Bastien Les vieilles choses, il faut les réparer. Pas les jeter.
Old things should be repaired. Not thrown away. (neutral)

Lucie Comme les vieilles maisons. Et les gens un peu cassés.
Like old houses. And people who are a bit broken. (moved)

Bastien Et les fantômes ?
And the ghosts? (teasing)

Lucie Les fantômes, on les garde comme ils sont.
The ghosts, we keep just as they are. (amused)

Words from this episode

- **je regardais cette véranda** *(zhuh ruh-gar-deh set vay-rahN-dah)* — I used to look at this veranda (imparfait)
- **Tu devrais la garder** *(tew duh-vreh lah gar-day)* — You should keep it (devoir in the conditional + infinitive)
- **On la répare** *(ohN lah ray-par)* — We repair it (la = la véranda)
- **Je l'ai ratée** *(zhuh lay rah-tay)* — I've botched it (l' = la vitre; -e agreement)
- **Tant pis** *(tahN pee)* — Never mind, too bad
- **Recommence** *(ruh-koh-mahNs)* — Start again (re + commencer, with tu)
- **trente-neuf** *(trahNt-nuhf)* — thirty-nine
- **il faut les réparer** *(eel foh lay ray-pah-ray)* — they must be repaired (il faut + infinitive)
- **Pas les jeter** *(pah lay zhuh-tay)* — Not throw them away (jeter)
- **on les garde** *(ohN lay gard)* — we keep them (garder; les = les fantômes)

Notice: la garder, on la répare, on les garde

Bastien says Tu devrais la garder and On la répare: la stands for la véranda and goes before the verb or the infinitive. In the passé composé it goes before avoir and the participle agrees: Je l'ai ratée (la vitre). For plurals, use les: il faut les réparer, on les garde.

See the table: Grammar tables, Direct object pronouns: me, le, la...

Sagesse du jour

« Vingt fois sur le métier remettez votre ouvrage. » *(vaN fwah sewr luh may-tyay ruh-meh-tay voh-truh oo-vrahzh)*

Literally: Twenty times on the loom put back your work.

Meaning: Good work is done again and again, patiently, until it's right.

Act 4 · L'ouverture (The opening)

Level B1

Episode 16 · L'inspection (The inspection)

On Thursday morning Denis, the fire safety inspector, arrives an hour early with a blank clipboard and a torch, while Lucie is at the bank. Eulalie curtseys to him in the hall, and he takes her for a receptionist in costume. When he opens the brass folding gate of the 1908 cage lift, Marcel's alarmed lilac face appears inside. At the end Denis peers down at Eulalie's shoes hovering above the tiles while she smiles innocently behind her fan.

Denis Bonjour, madame. Je voudrais voir les sorties de secours, s'il vous plaît.
Good morning, madam. I'd like to see the emergency exits, please. (neutral)

Eulalie Avec plaisir. Vous aimeriez commencer par le grenier ou par la cave ?
With pleasure. Would you like to start with the attic or the cellar? (proud)

Denis Joli costume. L'hôtel a un thème ?
Nice costume. Does the hotel have a theme? (curious)

Eulalie Pas vraiment. Je suis un fantôme de mille sept cent quatre-vingt-six.
Not really. I'm a ghost from 1786. (teasing)

Denis Ha ! Et moi, je suis Napoléon.
Ha! And I'm Napoleon. (amused)

Eulalie Le feu a besoin d'air. Monsieur Lavoisier l'a montré, il y a longtemps.
Fire needs air. Monsieur Lavoisier showed that, long ago. (proud)

Denis L'ascenseur date de mille neuf cent huit ? Je regrette, il faudrait le fermer.
The lift dates from 1908? I'm sorry, it would have to be closed. (US: the elevator) (sad)

Eulalie Marcel va être triste. Il l'aime tant, cet ascenseur.
Marcel is going to be sad. He loves that lift so much. (worried)

Eulalie On pourrait le transformer ? En petit cabinet de curiosités ?
Could we turn it into something else? A little cabinet of curiosities? (hopeful)

Denis Un cabinet de curiosités ? Ce serait original… et sans danger.
A cabinet of curiosities? That would be original… and safe. (surprised)

Eulalie Avant, nous nous ennuyions. Maintenant, nous travaillons.
Before, we were bored. Now, we work. (proud)

Denis Pour le reste, tout est parfait. Vous pourriez ouvrir le dix-neuf.
As for the rest, everything is perfect. You could open on the nineteenth. (neutral)

Denis Une dernière question : pourquoi vos pieds ne touchent pas le sol ?
One last question: why don't your feet touch the floor? (curious)

Eulalie Un fantôme ne ment jamais, monsieur.
A ghost never lies, sir. (amused)

Words from this episode

- **Je voudrais voir** *(zhuh voo-dreh vwahr)* — I'd like to see (polite request)
- **Avec plaisir** *(ah-vek pleh-zeer)* — With pleasure
- **Vous aimeriez commencer** *(voo‿zeh-muh-ryay koh-mahN-say)* — Would you like to start (aimer in the conditional)
- **Le feu a besoin d'air** *(luh fuh ah buh-zwaN dair)* — Fire needs air (avoir besoin de)
- **l'a montré** *(lah mohN-tray)* — showed it (montrer)
- **il faudrait le fermer** *(eel foh-dreh luh fair-may)* — it would have to be closed (falloir in the conditional)
- **On pourrait le transformer** *(ohN poo-reh luh trahNs-for-may)* — We could turn it into something else (pouvoir in the conditional)
- **Ce serait original** *(suh suh-reh oh-ree-zhee-nahl)* — That would be original
- **Vous pourriez ouvrir** *(voo poo-ree-yay oo-vreer)* — You could open (a soft permission)
- **Un fantôme ne ment jamais** *(uhN fahN-tohm nuh mahN zhah-meh)* — A ghost never lies (ne… jamais)

Notice: je voudrais, vous aimeriez, on pourrait

Denis and Eulalie stay polite with the conditional: Je voudrais voir…, Vous aimeriez commencer… ?, Il faudrait le fermer. It also softens an idea or a permission: On pourrait le transformer ?, Ce serait original, Vous pourriez ouvrir le dix-neuf.

See the table: Grammar tables, Conditional: would, could, polite requests.

Sagesse du jour

« Le travail éloigne de nous trois grands maux : l'ennui, le vice et le besoin. » *(luh trah-vahy ay-lwahny duh noo trwah grahN moh, lahN-nwee, luh vees ay luh buh-zwaN)*

Literally: Work keeps three great evils away from us: boredom, vice and need.

Meaning: Useful work keeps away boredom, bad habits and being poor.

Episode 17 · La tempête de neige (The snowstorm)

On Friday evening, eight days before the opening, the first big snowstorm closes the road and cuts the power. Lucie, who now sleeps in Hortense's old room behind reception, opens the front door with a candle to Raymond, an old man with snow on his beard, a pompom hat and a walking stick. In the dark, Anselme's amber glow and Marcel's lilac glow float down the corridor and light the way. Later Raymond sits by the kitchen fire in a blanket with a steaming bowl; tonight he will sleep on the salon sofa by the fire.

Raymond Bonsoir… Excusez-moi. Je suis perdu, et il fait très froid.
Good evening… Excuse me. I'm lost, and it's very cold. (worried)

Lucie Entrez ! Mais l'hôtel n'est pas encore ouvert. Il n'y a pas d'électricité.
Come in! But the hotel isn't open yet. There's no electricity. (worried)

Raymond Je pourrais dormir près du feu ? Juste cette nuit ?
Could I sleep by the fire? Just for tonight? (hopeful)

Lucie Bien sûr. Ici, la porte est toujours ouverte.
Of course. Here, the door is always open. (proud)

Raymond Qu'est-ce que c'est, ces lumières qui marchent dans le couloir ?
What are those lights walking along the corridor? (surprised)

Lucie Ce sont… les employés. Ils sont un peu spéciaux.
They're… the staff. They're a bit special. (amused)

Lucie Voilà une soupe que j'ai faite moi-même. La recette d'Anselme.
Here's a soup I made myself. Anselme's recipe. (proud)

Raymond Cette soupe… Je l'ai mangée ici, en mille neuf cent soixante-douze. Avec mes parents.
This soup… I ate it here, in 1972. With my parents. (moved)

Raymond La dame qui la servait riait tout le temps. Hortense, je crois.
The lady who served it laughed all the time. Hortense, I think. (moved)

Lucie C'était ma tante. Vous êtes le premier client qui dort ici depuis trente et un ans.
That was my aunt. You're the first guest to sleep here in thirty-one years. (moved)

Raymond Je n'ai rien pour payer…
I've got nothing to pay with… (sad)

Lucie Ce soir, c'est gratuit. Vous pourriez revenir le dix-neuf, pour l'ouverture ?
Tonight, it's free. Could you come back on the nineteenth, for the opening? (hopeful)

Raymond Avec ma femme, Monique. Elle adorerait cette soupe.
With my wife, Monique. She would love this soup. (hopeful)

Words from this episode

- **Bonsoir** *(bohN-swahr)* — Good evening
- **Excusez-moi** *(eks-kew-zay mwah)* — Excuse me
- **Je suis perdu** *(zhuh swee pair-dew)* — I'm lost (a man speaking; a woman says perdue)
- **Je pourrais dormir** *(zhuh poo-reh dor-meer)* — Could I sleep (pouvoir in the conditional + dormir)
- **Bien sûr** *(byaN sewr)* — Of course
- **ces lumières qui marchent** *(say lew-myair kee marsh)* — those lights that are walking (qui: subject)
- **une soupe que j'ai faite** *(ewn soop kuh zhay fet)* — a soup that I made (que: object; faite agrees)
- **Je l'ai mangée** *(zhuh lay mahN-zhay)* — I ate it (l' = la soupe; -e agreement)
- **La dame qui la servait** *(lah dahm kee lah sair-veh)* — The lady who served it (servir, imparfait)
- **Vous pourriez revenir** *(voo poo-ree-yay ruh-vuh-neer)* — Could you come back (revenir)

Notice: qui, que

Raymond asks about ces lumières qui marchent and remembers la dame qui la servait: qui is the subject of the next verb. Lucie offers une soupe que j'ai faite moi-même: que is the object and has its own subject after it (j'). Raymond is also le premier client qui dort ici depuis trente et un ans.

See the table: Grammar tables, Relative pronouns: qui, que, où, dont.

Sagesse du jour

« C'est la nuit qu'il est beau de croire à la lumière. » *(seh lah nwee keel eh boh duh krwahr ah lah lew-myair)*

Literally: It is at night that it is beautiful to believe in the light.

Meaning: The darkest moments are the right time to keep hope and believe in better days.

Episode 18 · La veille (The night before)

At eleven on Friday night, the eve of the opening, Marcel and Eulalie sit side by side on the old trunk in the turret, their lilac and blue glows mixing; beyond the round window there is snow and stars. Anselme is in the kitchen, and the smell of soup rises up the stairs, while Lucie sleeps downstairs in Hortense's old room. Below, the old cage lift is now lined with shelves of curiosities. At the end Marcel makes an exaggerated bow, and Eulalie laughs behind her fan.

Marcel Demain, douze chambres pleines. J'aimerais être content… mais j'ai peur des clients.
Tomorrow, twelve full rooms. I'd like to be happy… but I'm afraid of the guests. (worried)

Eulalie Vous en avez peur, vous aussi ? Moi, j'en ai peur depuis une semaine.
You're afraid of them too? I've been afraid of them for a week. (worried)

Eulalie On pourrait se cacher, comme avant ?
We could hide, like before? (hopeful)

Marcel Se cacher ? Nous y sommes restés cachés trente et un ans. Non, merci.
Hide? We stayed hidden in this house for thirty-one years. No, thank you. (annoyed)

Eulalie Et s'ils se moquent de nous ? De ma robe, de vos moustaches ?
And what if they make fun of us? Of my dress, of your moustache? (worried)

Marcel Mes moustaches sont parfaites depuis cent ans, madame.
My moustache has been perfect for a hundred years, madam. (teasing)

Marcel Et mon ascenseur est fermé. Tout change.
And my lift is closed. Everything is changing. (sad)

Eulalie Quelle merveille ! Votre ascenseur est devenu le plus joli cabinet de curiosités des Alpes.
What a marvel! Your lift has become the prettiest cabinet of curiosities in the Alps. (hopeful)

Eulalie Alors, s'ils rient, on rit avec eux. Et on rit les premiers.
So if they laugh, we laugh with them. And we laugh first. (proud)

Marcel C'est épatant ! On y va, demain ? Ensemble ?
That's splendid! Shall we go for it, tomorrow? Together? (amused)

Eulalie Lucie dort en bas. Elle n'a plus peur, elle.
Lucie is asleep downstairs. She isn't afraid any more. (moved)

Marcel Vous savez, madame Eulalie ? Après cent ans, on pourrait se dire tu ?
You know what, Madame Eulalie? After a hundred years, we could say tu to each other? (moved)

Eulalie Jamais de la vie, monsieur Marcel. Bonne nuit.
Not on your life, Monsieur Marcel. Good night. (amused)

Words from this episode

- **J'aimerais être content** *(zhem-reh eh-truh kohN-tahN)* — I'd like to be happy (aimer in the conditional; a man speaking)
- **Vous en avez peur** *(voo‿zahN‿nah-vay puhr)* — You're afraid of them (en = des clients)
- **j'en ai peur** *(zhahN‿nay puhr)* — I'm afraid of them
- **On pourrait se cacher** *(ohN poo-reh suh kah-shay)* — We could hide (a soft suggestion)
- **nous y sommes restés** *(noo‿zee sum res-tay)* — we stayed there (y = ici; rester, with être)
- **Tout change** *(too shahNzh)* — Everything is changing (changer)
- **est devenu** *(eh duh-vuh-new)* — has become (devenir, with être)
- **on rit avec eux** *(ohN ree ah-vek uh)* — we laugh with them (rire)
- **On y va** *(ohN‿nee vah)* — Shall we go? Let's go
- **Bonne nuit** *(bun nwee)* — Good night

Notice: en, y

Eulalie asks Vous en avez peur ? and answers J'en ai peur: en replaces de + a thing or people (avoir peur des clients). Marcel says nous y sommes restés and On y va ?: y replaces a place (ici, in the house).

See the table: Grammar tables, Y and en.

Sagesse du jour

« Je me presse de rire de tout, de peur d'être obligé d'en pleurer. » *(zhuh muh pres duh reer duh too, duh puhr deh-truh oh-blee-zhay dahN pluh-ray)*

Literally: I hurry to laugh at everything, for fear of being forced to cry about it.

Meaning: Laughing at your troubles is better than crying over them.

Episode 19 · Les premiers clients (The first guests)

On Saturday afternoon, opening day, the hall is decorated with pine branches and candles. Hélène Garnier stamps the snow off her boots with her children Margot and Sacha, while her husband Olivier silently carries the bags. Marcel is upstairs showing Raymond and Monique to their room, so Anselme has taken the reception desk, glowing amber; Margot stares at him and waves shyly. Anselme bows low with his wooden ladle, and later a soup tureen steams on the long table of the vaulted dining room.

Hélène Bonjour ! Nous sommes les Garnier. Mon mari a réservé en octobre, au téléphone.
Hello! We're the Garniers. My husband booked in October, by phone. (neutral)

Anselme Bienvenue, madame ! Nous vous attendions… depuis trente et un ans.
Welcome, madam! We've been waiting for you… for thirty-one years. (proud)

Hélène Mon mari m'a dit que la dame au téléphone avait un accent ancien.
My husband told me the lady on the phone had an old-fashioned accent. (amused)

Anselme C'était Eulalie. Elle est ici depuis deux cent quarante ans.
That was Eulalie. She's been here for two hundred and forty years. (teasing)

Hélène Ah, l'hôtel a un thème : les fantômes ! C'est très bien fait.
Oh, the hotel has a theme: ghosts! It's very well done. (amused)

Hélène Ma fille vous dit bonjour. Elle dit que vous brillez.
My daughter says hello to you. She says you're glowing. (surprised)

Anselme Les enfants nous voient toujours. Dites-lui bonjour de ma part.
Children can always see us. Say hello to her from me. (moved)

Hélène Vous êtes… vraiment un fantôme ?
Are you… really a ghost? (worried)

Anselme Un fantôme gentil, madame. Règle numéro un : on ne fait jamais peur.
A gentle ghost, madam. Rule number one: we never frighten anyone. (proud)

Hélène Alors tout va bien. Les enfants adorent les fantômes gentils.
Then everything's fine. Children love gentle ghosts. (relieved)

Anselme Le dîner est à sept heures : ma soupe aux choux. Ici, qui dort dîne !
Dinner is at seven: my cabbage soup. Here, if you sleep, you dine! (proud)

Hélène On voudrait quatre bols. Et un pour le fantôme ?
We'd like four bowls. And one for the ghost? (teasing)

Anselme Fort bien, madame ! Moi, je me contente de l'odeur. Maintenant, c'est Lucie qui cuisine.
Very well, madam! I make do with the smell. Now, Lucie is the one who cooks. (amused)

Words from this episode

- **Bonjour** *(bohN-zhoor)* — Hello
- **Mon mari a réservé en octobre** *(mohN mah-ree ah ray-zair-vay ahN‿nok-toh-bruh)* — My husband booked in October (en + month)
- **Nous vous attendions** *(noo voo‿zah-tahN-dyohN)* — We were waiting for you (attendre, imparfait)
- **Mon mari m'a dit** *(mohN mah-ree mah dee)* — My husband told me (m' = to me)
- **Ma fille vous dit bonjour** *(mah feey voo dee bohN-zhoor)* — My daughter says hello to you (dire à: vous)
- **Les enfants nous voient** *(lay‿zahN-fahN noo vwah)* — Children see us (voir)
- **Dites-lui bonjour** *(deet lwee bohN-zhoor)* — Say hello to her (lui = to her)
- **à sept heures** *(ah se-tuhr)* — at seven o'clock
- **qui dort dîne** *(kee dor deen)* — whoever sleeps, dines (dormir)
- **On voudrait quatre bols** *(ohN voo-dreh kah-truh bol)* — We'd like four bowls (polite conditional)

Notice: vous dit, m'a dit, dites-lui

With dire à quelqu'un, the person becomes a small pronoun before the verb: Ma fille vous dit bonjour, Mon mari m'a dit que… (me becomes m' before a vowel). In an order, it goes after the verb with a hyphen: Dites-lui bonjour, where lui means 'to her'.

See the table: Grammar tables, Indirect object pronouns: me, lui, leur...

Sagesse du jour

« Qui dort dîne. » *(kee dor deen)*

Literally: Who sleeps dines.

Meaning: Sleep makes you forget you're hungry; old innkeepers meant: if you sleep here, you dine here.

Episode 20 · L'ouverture (The opening)

At ten on Saturday night, the opening night, Lucie in a green dress and Marcel stand side by side at the reception desk with the brass bell. In the firelit salon behind them the guests sing; Eulalie shows Margot the stars over Mont Blanc from the window, and Anselme sniffs the leftover soup. The doorbell rings: two skiers whose car is stuck in the snow. Lucie flings open the double oak doors on the falling snow, the three ghosts glowing behind her, and the skiers will sleep on the salon sofas by the fire, as Raymond did.

Lucie Ouf. Le dîner est fini. Tout le monde est content, je crois.
Phew. Dinner's over. Everyone's happy, I think. (relieved)

Marcel Douze chambres pleines, madame. C'est épatant ! Comme en janvier mille neuf cent vingt-quatre.
Twelve full rooms, madam. It's splendid! Like in January 1924. (proud)

Lucie Et la petite Margot a donné un nom à l'hôtel.
And little Margot has given the hotel a name. (amused)

Marcel Ah oui ? Lequel ?
Oh yes? Which one? (curious)

Lucie « L'hôtel des fantômes gentils ». Les deux enfants le répètent.
'The Hotel of the Gentle Ghosts'. Both children keep saying it. (amused)

Marcel Les fantômes gentils… J'aimerais bien garder ce nom, moi.
The gentle ghosts… I'd really like to keep that name. (moved)

Lucie Moi aussi. Ce serait le nom parfait. On le garde !
Me too. It would be the perfect name. We're keeping it! (teasing)

Marcel Madame Lucie… vous avez trouvé ce que vous cherchiez ?
Madame Lucie… have you found what you were looking for? (curious)

Lucie En septembre, je n'étais chez moi nulle part. Ce soir, je suis chez moi.
In September, I wasn't at home anywhere. Tonight, I'm at home. (moved)

Marcel Madame Hortense serait fière de vous. Et nous aussi, nous sommes fiers.
Madame Hortense would be proud of you. And we're proud too. (hopeful)

Lucie Et vous, Marcel ? Vous vous ennuyez encore ?
And you, Marcel? Are you still bored? (curious)

Marcel M'ennuyer ? Avec douze chambres, deux enfants et un ascenseur plein de trésors ?
Me, bored? With twelve rooms, two children and a lift full of treasures? (amused)

Marcel La porte, madame ? C'est à vous, maintenant.
The door, madam? It's yours now. (neutral)

Lucie Bonsoir ! Entrez, entrez. Bienvenue chez nous.
Good evening! Come in, come in. Welcome to our home. (proud)

Words from this episode

- **Le dîner est fini** *(luh dee-nay eh fee-nee)* — Dinner is over (finir)
- **Douze chambres pleines** *(dooz shahN-bruh plen)* — Twelve full rooms
- **Les deux enfants le répètent** *(lay duh‿zahN-fahN luh ray-pet)* — Both children keep saying it (répéter)
- **J'aimerais bien garder ce nom** *(zhem-reh byaN gar-day suh nohN)* — I'd really like to keep that name (a wish)
- **Moi aussi** *(mwah oh-see)* — Me too
- **Ce serait le nom parfait** *(suh suh-reh luh nohN par-feh)* — It would be the perfect name
- **vous avez trouvé ce que vous cherchiez** *(voo‿zah-vay troo-vay suh kuh voo shair-shyay)* — have you found what you were looking for (chercher, imparfait)
- **je suis chez moi** *(zhuh swee shay mwah)* — I'm at home
- **Entrez, entrez** *(ahN-tray, ahN-tray)* — Come in, come in (entrer)
- **Bonsoir** *(bohN-swahr)* — Good evening

Notice: j'aimerais, ce serait, serait fière

Marcel makes a wish with J'aimerais bien garder ce nom, and Lucie agrees: Ce serait le nom parfait. Marcel then imagines Hortense's feelings: Madame Hortense serait fière de vous. The conditional softens a wish or an imagined feeling; the present then makes the decision: On le garde !

See the table: Grammar tables, Conditional: would, could, polite requests.

Sagesse du jour

« Il faut cultiver notre jardin. » *(eel foh kewl-tee-vay noh-truh zhar-daN)*

Literally: We must cultivate our garden.

Meaning: Stop worrying about the whole world: take care of your own place and its people.

Questions

Episode 1 · L'héritière

1. Why is Lucie surprised when Marcel asks about a booking?
   a. She has no money
   b. She is in the wrong village
   c. The hotel is full
   d. The hotel is hers
2. Who is Marcel?
   a. An estate agent
   b. Lucie's uncle
   c. The hotel's ghost concierge
   d. The village carpenter
3. How long has Lucie's room been ready?
   a. One night
   b. Thirteen years
   c. Thirty-one years
   d. Twenty-one years
4. What does Marcel say about the word 'impossible'?
   a. C'est mon mot préféré, madame.
   b. Ce mot est très joli, madame.
   c. Je dis ce mot tous les jours.
   d. Je ne connais pas ce mot, madame.

Episode 2 · La soupe

1. What does Lucie usually eat in the evening?
   a. Biscuits
   b. Bread and jam
   c. Cheese
   d. Soup
2. Why can't Anselme make the soup himself?
   a. He doesn't like soup
   b. He has no recipe
   c. His hands can't hold anything
   d. The fire is out
3. Since when has Anselme's inn been here?
   a. Since 1680
   b. Since 1786
   c. Since 1908
   d. Since 1924
4. What does Anselme say at the end?
   a. Une cuisine commence avec des biscuits.
   b. Une maison commence dans la cuisine.
   c. Une maison commence dans le salon.
   d. Une soupe commence avec du fromage.

Episode 3 · Le télescope

1. Who does Bastien think Eulalie is?
   a. A new guest
   b. A painter from Chamonix
   c. An actress in costume
   d. Lucie's sister
2. What does Eulalie admit about hiding?
   a. It's frightening
   b. It's quiet, but she's bored
   c. It's very tiring
   d. She loves it every day
3. Since what year has Eulalie lived here?
   a. 1680
   b. 1786
   c. 1924
   d. 1995
4. What will Bastien bring tomorrow?
   a. Demain, avec de la peinture.
   b. Demain, avec des fleurs.
   c. Demain, avec des tuiles.
   d. Demain, avec un télescope.

Episode 4 · L'agent immobilier

1. What does Gérard blame when the shutter opens by itself?
   a. A cat
   b. Draughts
   c. Lucie
   d. The ghosts
2. Why does Lucie feel she is at home nowhere?
   a. She has no money
   b. She is always at work
   c. She lives in hotels
   d. She moves to a new city every year
3. What price does Gérard give?
   a. 10,000 euros
   b. 100,000 euros
   c. 120 euros
   d. 20,000 euros
4. What does Lucie finally answer?
   a. Je ne sais pas. Peut-être demain.
   b. Non. Je ne vends pas. Pas aujourd'hui.
   c. Oui. Cent mille euros, c'est parfait.
   d. Oui. Je vends vite.

Episode 5 · Le pacte

1. What do the ghosts propose?
   a. Lucie cooks for them
   b. Lucie opens the hotel and they help
   c. They leave the house
   d. They sell the hotel
2. Why does Lucie add a rule about doors?
   a. Anselme has just walked through the wall
   b. Marcel has lost the keys
   c. The doors are broken
   d. The guests are arriving
3. When will the hotel open?
   a. On 1 December
   b. On 19 December
   c. On 19 September
   d. On 31 October
4. What is rule number two?
   a. Un fantôme ne dort jamais.
   b. Un fantôme ne mange jamais.
   c. Un fantôme ne ment jamais.
   d. Un fantôme ne sort jamais.

Episode 6 · Le toit

1. What did Lucie buy before mending the roof?
   a. A ladder
   b. New windows
   c. Paint
   d. Tiles
2. Why is Lucie scared of going on the roof?
   a. Bastien is late
   b. She doesn't like the rain
   c. She has lost the keys
   d. She has never been up a ladder
3. How many steps does Lucie climb?
   a. Ten
   b. Three
   c. Twenty
   d. Two
4. What does Lucie say about her concierge?
   a. Euh… il est dans la cuisine.
   b. Euh… il est parti en vacances.
   c. Euh… il est parti à Lyon.
   d. Euh… il est sur le toit.

Episode 7 · La tartiflette

1. Why did Josette get a fright in 1958?
   a. She got lost in the snow
   b. She saw a bear
   c. She saw Anselme
   d. The kitchen caught fire
2. Why is Anselme surprised by the tartiflette?
   a. He hates cheese
   b. He's from Savoy and has never eaten it
   c. It's too hot
   d. Josette has burnt it
3. When was tartiflette invented?
   a. In 1924
   b. In 1958
   c. In the 1680s
   d. In the 1980s
4. What did Hortense ask Josette to do?
   a. Aider la petite.
   b. Cuisiner pour les fantômes.
   c. Fermer la cuisine.
   d. Vendre l'hôtel.

Episode 8 · Les noms des chambres

1. What kind of names does Eulalie want for the rooms?
   a. Names of famous guests
   b. Names of flowers
   c. Names of mountains
   d. Names of old kings
2. What did Marcel do during the night?
   a. He cooked a soup
   b. He mended the radiator
   c. He painted the doors
   d. He polished the twelve keys twice
3. Which room is Myosotis?
   a. Room one
   b. Room seven
   c. Room twelve
   d. Room two
4. What does Marcel say every morning?
   a. Tous les jours, je dis bonjour aux clients.
   b. Tous les jours, je fais briller les clés.
   c. Tous les jours, je regarde la montagne.
   d. Tous les jours, je vais de mieux en mieux.

Episode 9 · La première réservation

1. What surprises Eulalie at the start?
    a. A voice comes out of the telephone
    b. Lucie is calling from the bank
    c. Marcel is shouting
    d. The telephone is broken
2. What makes Olivier book the room?
    a. The famous restaurant
    b. The hot chocolate and the telescope
    c. The low price
    d. The swimming pool
3. How much is the room?
    a. 100 euros
    b. 120 euros
    c. 20 euros
    d. 90 euros
4. When does Olivier want a room?
    a. Le dix-neuf décembre.
    b. Le dix-neuf septembre.
    c. Le trente et un décembre.
    d. Le vingt et un octobre.

Episode 10 · Tout le village

1. Why does Lucie want to sell?
    a. Bastien wants to buy it
    b. She misses Lille
    c. The bank said no and she is short of money
    d. The ghosts are too noisy
2. How does Bastien know about the ghosts?
    a. Anselme visited his workshop
    b. He read about them in a book
    c. His grandmother told him everything
    d. Lucie told him last week
3. In what year did Bastien see Marcel?
    a. 1958
    b. 1995
    c. 1996
    d. 2005
4. What is the plan for Saturday?
    a. Samedi, je vais partir à Lille.
    b. Samedi, on va fermer l'hôtel.
    c. Samedi, on va réparer l'hôtel. Ensemble.
    d. Samedi, on va vendre l'hôtel.

Episode 11 · Le sommet

1. What did Eulalie do when the climbers reached the top?
   a. She climbed after them
   b. She cried with joy
   c. She fell asleep
   d. She rang the church bell
2. Why didn't Eulalie climb in 1786?
   a. A lady couldn't do that in those days
   b. Her uncle was ill
   c. She had no boots
   d. She was afraid of the snow
3. When did the first woman reach the summit?
   a. In 1786
   b. In 1808
   c. In 1860
   d. In 1924
4. What does Nathan advise Eulalie?
   a. Vous devriez fermer la fenêtre.
   b. Vous devriez monter au sommet avec moi.
   c. Vous devriez montrer la montagne aux clients.
   d. Vous devriez vendre ce télescope.

Episode 12 · L'auberge

1. Why does Anselme tease Lucie?
   a. She has broken a door
   b. She has burnt the soup
   c. She has forgotten his name
   d. She has said 'one more door' for three nights
2. What does Anselme say about the muleteers?
   a. They always got lost on the pass
   b. They never paid for their soup
   c. They never wore out their mules
   d. They sang all night
3. When did Savoy become French?
   a. In 1680
   b. In 1786
   c. In 1860
   d. In 1924
4. What advice does Anselme give Lucie?
   a. Vous devriez dormir, madame.
   b. Vous devriez manger, madame.
   c. Vous devriez partir en Italie.
   d. Vous devriez vendre la porte.

Episode 13 · Les Jeux d'hiver

1. Who is the young woman next to Marcel in the photo?
   a. A famous skater
   b. Hortense as a girl
   c. Josette's grandmother, Germaine
   d. Marcel's sister
2. How did Marcel feel after the winter of 1924?
   a. Angry: the guests were rude
   b. Bored: there was too much snow
   c. Happy: he could rest at last
   d. Sad: the hotel was quiet and he missed those days
3. Where were the first Winter Olympic Games held?
   a. In Annecy
   b. In Chamonix
   c. In Lyon
   d. In Paris
4. What does Josette advise Marcel?
   a. Vous devriez cacher cette photo.
   b. Vous devriez chanter avec les clients.
   c. Vous devriez fermer le salon.
   d. Vous devriez raconter ces histoires aux clients.

Episode 14 · Tante Hortense

1. What did Hortense and Marcel do every Sunday?
   a. They cooked a soup
   b. They played cards
   c. They polished the keys
   d. They watched the mountain
2. Why did Hortense close the hotel?
   a. She moved to Lille
   b. She was tired and had no one to carry on
   c. The ghosts scared the guests
   d. The roof fell in
3. How old was the little girl who came one summer?
   a. Eight
   b. Five
   c. Sixteen
   d. Twenty-nine
4. What did Hortense use to say?
   a. Une maison commence dans la cuisine.
   b. Une maison, c'est un toit solide.
   c. Une maison, c'est une porte fermée.
   d. Une maison, c'est une porte ouverte.

Episode 15 · La véranda

1. What did the window company offer?
   a. All plastic, in one week
   b. Free glass for the veranda
   c. New wooden frames, in a month
   d. To mend the roof
2. Why does Bastien want to keep the veranda?
   a. As a boy, he saw it shine like a jewel
   b. He built it himself
   c. Lucie's aunt asked him to
   d. Plastic is too expensive
3. When was the veranda built?
   a. In 1786
   b. In 1908
   c. In 1924
   d. In 1995
4. What does Lucie say about the ghosts?
   a. Les fantômes, on les cache.
   b. Les fantômes, on les garde comme ils sont.
   c. Les fantômes, on les jette.
   d. Les fantômes, on les répare.

Episode 16 · L'inspection

1. Who does Denis think Eulalie is?
   a. A real ghost
   b. A receptionist in costume
   c. An actress from Paris
   d. The owner of the hotel
2. What does Denis say about the old lift?
   a. It is perfect
   b. It is too small for guests
   c. It needs new paint
   d. It would have to be closed
3. According to Eulalie, what did Lavoisier show?
   a. That fire needs air
   b. That fire needs water
   c. That ghosts can't burn
   d. That snow is made of air
4. What does Eulalie suggest for the lift?
   a. On pourrait le cacher dans la cave ?
   b. On pourrait le peindre en jaune ?
   c. On pourrait le transformer ? En petit cabinet de curiosités ?
   d. On pourrait le vendre à Chamonix ?

Episode 17 · La tempête de neige

1. Why does Raymond knock at the door?
   a. He has a booking
   b. He is looking for Bastien
   c. He is lost and very cold
   d. He wants to buy the hotel
2. What does Lucie say the moving lights are?
   a. Candles in the wind
   b. Car headlights
   c. The firemen's torches
   d. The staff, who are a bit special
3. When did Raymond eat this soup here before?
   a. In 1958
   b. In 1972
   c. In 1995
   d. In 2005
4. What does Lucie invite Raymond to do?
   a. Dormir dans la cave.
   b. Partir demain matin, très tôt.
   c. Payer la chambre demain.
   d. Revenir le dix-neuf, pour l'ouverture.

Episode 18 · La veille

1. Why is Marcel worried the night before the opening?
   a. He's afraid of the guests
   b. Lucie wants to sell
   c. The lift is broken again
   d. The soup is cold
2. What does Eulalie decide to do if the guests laugh?
   a. Ask them to leave
   b. Cry in the attic
   c. Hide in the turret
   d. Laugh with them, and laugh first
3. How long did the ghosts stay hidden?
   a. A hundred years
   b. Eight days
   c. Thirteen years
   d. Thirty-one years
4. What does Eulalie answer when Marcel suggests saying tu?
   a. Avec plaisir, mon cher Marcel.
   b. Bien sûr, mon ami.
   c. Jamais de la vie, monsieur Marcel.
   d. Oui, demain matin.

Episode 19 · Les premiers clients

1. What does Hélène think at first about the ghost at the desk?
   a. It's a famous actor
   b. It's her husband in a costume
   c. It's part of a ghost theme, very well done
   d. It's the village carpenter
2. What does Margot say about Anselme?
   a. That he is glowing
   b. That he is scary
   c. That he is too tall
   d. That he smells of soup
3. What time is dinner?
   a. At eight
   b. At half past seven
   c. At seven
   d. At six
4. What is the ghosts' rule number one?
   a. On ne fait jamais peur.
   b. On ne mange jamais.
   c. On ne ment jamais.
   d. On prend les portes.

Episode 20 · L'ouverture

1. What name has Margot given the hotel?
   a. The Hotel of the Gentle Ghosts
   b. The Hotel of the Stars
   c. The House of Soup
   d. The Mont Blanc Inn
2. How does Lucie feel on opening night?
   a. At home at last
   b. Bored with the guests
   c. Tired and ready to leave
   d. Worried about money
3. When was the hotel last this full?
   a. In 1786
   b. In 1972
   c. In 2005
   d. In January 1924
4. What does Lucie say when she opens the door?
   a. Bonsoir ! Désolée, c'est complet.
   b. Bonsoir ! Entrez, entrez. Bienvenue chez nous.
   c. Bonsoir ! L'hôtel est fermé.
   d. Bonsoir ! Revenez demain matin.

Answer key

1.1 d) The hotel is hers
1.2 c) The hotel's ghost concierge
1.3 c) Thirty-one years
1.4 d) Je ne connais pas ce mot, madame.
2.1 a) Biscuits
2.2 c) His hands can't hold anything
2.3 a) Since 1680
2.4 b) Une maison commence dans la cuisine.
3.1 c) An actress in costume
3.2 b) It's quiet, but she's bored
3.3 b) 1786
3.4 c) Demain, avec des tuiles.
4.1 b) Draughts
4.2 d) She moves to a new city every year
4.3 b) 100,000 euros
4.4 b) Non. Je ne vends pas. Pas aujourd'hui.
5.1 b) Lucie opens the hotel and they help
5.2 a) Anselme has just walked through the wall
5.3 b) On 19 December
5.4 c) Un fantôme ne ment jamais.
6.1 c) Paint
6.2 d) She has never been up a ladder
6.3 b) Three
6.4 b) Euh… il est parti en vacances.
7.1 c) She saw Anselme
7.2 b) He's from Savoy and has never eaten it
7.3 d) In the 1980s
7.4 a) Aider la petite.
8.1 b) Names of flowers
8.2 d) He polished the twelve keys twice
8.3 b) Room seven
8.4 d) Tous les jours, je vais de mieux en mieux.
9.1 a) A voice comes out of the telephone
9.2 b) The hot chocolate and the telescope
9.3 b) 120 euros
9.4 a) Le dix-neuf décembre.
10.1 c) The bank said no and she is short of money
10.2 c) His grandmother told him everything
10.3 c) 1996
10.4 c) Samedi, on va réparer l'hôtel. Ensemble.
11.1 b) She cried with joy
11.2 a) A lady couldn't do that in those days
11.3 b) In 1808
11.4 c) Vous devriez montrer la montagne aux clients.
12.1 d) She has said 'one more door' for three nights
12.2 c) They never wore out their mules
12.3 c) In 1860
12.4 a) Vous devriez dormir, madame.
13.1 c) Josette's grandmother, Germaine
13.2 d) Sad: the hotel was quiet and he missed those days
13.3 b) In Chamonix
13.4 d) Vous devriez raconter ces histoires aux clients.
14.1 b) They played cards
14.2 b) She was tired and had no one to carry on
14.3 a) Eight
14.4 d) Une maison, c'est une porte ouverte.
15.1 a) All plastic, in one week
15.2 a) As a boy, he saw it shine like a jewel
15.3 b) In 1908
15.4 b) Les fantômes, on les garde comme ils sont.
16.1 b) A receptionist in costume
16.2 d) It would have to be closed
16.3 a) That fire needs air
16.4 c) On pourrait le transformer ? En petit cabinet de curiosités ?
17.1 c) He is lost and very cold
17.2 d) The staff, who are a bit special
17.3 b) In 1972
17.4 d) Revenir le dix-neuf, pour l'ouverture.
18.1 a) He's afraid of the guests
18.2 d) Laugh with them, and laugh first
18.3 d) Thirty-one years
18.4 c) Jamais de la vie, monsieur Marcel.
19.1 c) It's part of a ghost theme, very well done
19.2 a) That he is glowing
19.3 c) At seven
19.4 a) On ne fait jamais peur.
20.1 a) The Hotel of the Gentle Ghosts
20.2 a) At home at last
20.3 d) In January 1924
20.4 b) Bonsoir ! Entrez, entrez. Bienvenue chez nous.

Proverb index

- Episode 1 · « Le vent se lève, il faut tenter de vivre. » — When things get hard or start to change, don't give up: try, and live fully.
- Episode 2 · « Il faut manger pour vivre et non pas vivre pour manger. » — Eat properly to stay well, but don't make food your whole life.
- Episode 3 · « Pour vivre heureux, vivons cachés. » — A quiet life out of sight keeps you safe and content.
- Episode 4 · « Pierre qui roule n'amasse pas mousse. » — If you never stay anywhere, you never build roots, friends or a home.
- Episode 5 · « L'important dans la vie, ce n'est point le triomphe mais le combat. » — What counts is to take part and do your best, not only to win.
- Episode 6 · « Il ne faut pas mettre la charrue avant les bœufs. » — Do things in the right order: the most important step comes first.
- Episode 7 · « Rien de nouveau sous le soleil. » — What looks new has usually been done before, in another form.
- Episode 8 · « La critique est aisée, et l'art est difficile. » — It's easy to find fault in other people's work; doing it yourself is hard.
- Episode 9 · « Le superflu, chose très nécessaire. » — The small extras that seem useless are what make life pleasant.
- Episode 10 · « Aide-toi, le ciel t'aidera. » — Make the first move yourself, and help will come.
- Episode 11 · « Chacun son métier, les vaches seront bien gardées. » — Let everyone do the job they know best, and all will go well.
- Episode 12 · « Qui veut voyager loin ménage sa monture. » — Look after your strength if you want to go a long way.
- Episode 13 · « Tous les jours, à tous points de vue, je vais de mieux en mieux. » — Tell yourself each day that things are getting better: your best days can still be ahead.
- Episode 14 · « Aujourd'hui plus qu'hier et bien moins que demain. » — Love for the people you care about grows a little more every day.
- Episode 15 · « Vingt fois sur le métier remettez votre ouvrage. » — Good work is done again and again, patiently, until it's right.
- Episode 16 · « Le travail éloigne de nous trois grands maux : l'ennui, le vice et le besoin. » — Useful work keeps away boredom, bad habits and being poor.
- Episode 17 · « C'est la nuit qu'il est beau de croire à la lumière. » — The darkest moments are the right time to keep hope and believe in better days.
- Episode 18 · « Je me presse de rire de tout, de peur d'être obligé d'en pleurer. » — Laughing at your troubles is better than crying over them.
- Episode 19 · « Qui dort dîne. » — Sleep makes you forget you're hungry; old innkeepers meant: if you sleep here, you dine here.
- Episode 20 · « Il faut cultiver notre jardin. » — Stop worrying about the whole world: take care of your own place and its people.

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